said with certainty is that had an invasion proceeded, US paratroopers and marines would have encountered a much larger Soviet force than they anticipated (as well as the still larger numbers of Cuban troops and militia). Raymond Garthoff explains that US estimates of Soviet military personnel rose from 8,000-10,000 on 22 October to some 12,000-16,000 by 19 November.[58] Re-analysis in early 1963 put the figure at 22,000. The actual figure was just under 42,000. Moreover, some 35,000 of these were combat troops and not just technicians.[59]

‘Any missile launched from Cuba …’

In October 1962 no one in the Kennedy administration seriously believed that Khrushchev intended to fire the missiles once they were installed. In a war, however, the Joint Chiefs were exercised that MRBMs (and IRBMs) could strike SAC bomber bases, ICBM sites, and command headquarters. Whether the R-12s had the necessary accuracy to destroy military targets (and, therefore, whether they would have been aimed at them rather than US cities) is far less clear. Operation Anadyr envisaged deployment of forty MRBM and IRBM launchers. US estimates mistakenly assumed each launcher would have a second missile for a second salvo (in fact the ratio of launcher to missile was two to three). The estimate of eighty missiles in Cuba doubled the estimated Soviet first strike capability. In fact, the Soviets intended to deploy thirty-six MRBMs and twenty-four IRBMs (there were also a further six MRBMs for training purposes). However, notwithstanding the intelligence community’s reassessment of Soviet ICBM strength in the autumn of 1961, US intelligence still overestimated their adversary’s capabilities. So, assuming a Soviet strength of forty or so ICBMs, the planned sixty MRBM and IRBMs would have increased land-based missile capabilities by some 150% (a figure that did not involve Soviet long-range bombers or submarine-based weapons).

If the missile sites were attacked, there was understandable concern that surviving missiles would be launched at US cities. Among the imponderables in assessing the likely success of a US attack was its timing. It took several days for the U-2s to complete coverage of the island, and